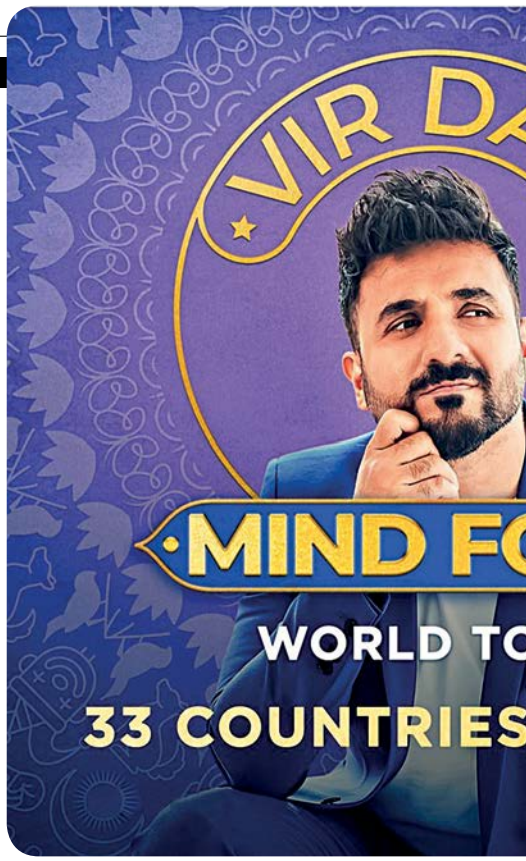


"I come from an India..." When Vir Das voiced those words in a seven-minute video uploaded on his YouTube channel on November 15, 2021, little did he know he'd become the headline. The 'Two Indias' spoken word would earn the stand-up comic and actor many brickbats as well as a few bouquets. Somewhere it hit a nerve as viewers came up with their own reflections on the unsettling dualities of India. In the video's aftermath, Das shunned the media and had a few of his gigs in India cancelled. He later addressed the controversy in a Netflix special, *Landing*, his best and most-watched so far. "What I learned in a reasonably hard way is that your content may become controversial, but controversy should never become your content," says Das, reflecting on the episode. "I made sure that I write a joke about how what happened was ridiculous and make it one that both sides could laugh at."

With 'Two Indias' long behind him, Das is embarking on his biggest world tour to date, performing in 33 countries and 35 cities in India. Titled 'Mind Fool', the tour kicks off in September and will go on till the end of 2024, with Das performing at venues like Carnegie Hall, The Kennedy Center and Dubai Opera. This time around, don't expect any commentary on politics even if it is election time both in India and the United States next year. "People are fatigued with politics. There's no novelty in the political joke anymore," says Das. "At some point, you can't charge people money for s*** they are doing on Twitter [now X] for free. People are coming to escape that stuff." Instead, his new set taps into his reluctance to be an adult even at 40. "Because of sheer stubbornness and fame, I have resisted growing up...but have had to learn to in the last year," he says.

Das is part of a small but significant legion of Indian comics like Zakir Khan and Anubhav Singh Bassi who are expanding their geographical footprint. Unlike them, Das predominantly performs in English, which means that the audience in his shows isn't restricted to the Indian diaspora but also includes locals abroad.

MUSIC

Just the Ticket!

The music festival season is shaping up to be busier than ever before—but you may need to book now



YASH BHANUSHALI

The Saturday and Sunday after Republic Day are now officially the **Lollapalooza India** weekend. The cross-continental multi-genre festival, which launched its first Asia edition in Mumbai last year, will return to the metropolis in 2024 on January 27 and 28.

Lollapalooza joins several music festivals that occupy fixed weekends. There's the **Mahindra Blues Festival**, also in Mumbai, on the second weekend of February and Arunachal Pradesh's multi-genre **Ziro Festival of Music** in the last weekend of September; while three electronic music-focused festivals, the environmentally-themed **Echoes of Earth** in Bengaluru, the limited-capacity, alternative-oriented **Magnetic Fields** in Rajasthan and the mainstream EDM extravaganza **Sunburn**, have reserved the beginning, middle and end of December, respectively.

Tickets for many of these are already on sale, with most categories for Magnetic Fields sold out. The online box-office for Lollapalooza, promoted and co-produced by BookMyShow along with American festival founder Perry Farrell and US organiser C3 Presents, opens